Whips and Windfalls

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36469996.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Mutual Pining, Pining, Secret Identity, Alternate Universe - Superheroes/Superpowers, Confessions, First Dates, Secret Crush, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Bright Moon (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Oblivious Catra (She-Ra), Useless Lesbians, Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic

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Part 2 of Masks and Mistakes Universe

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by ResFlower

Summary

"You know, I've been telling you for ages to ask Adora out. What brought this on?" Catra looks into her own coffee cup, collecting her words.

"I guess just hit me yesterday that we are always in danger. I might not get another five years to gather the courage to tell her." She told She-ra she didn't regret not telling Adora her feelings but now that the dust had settled something about Adora never knowing how important she is to Catra leaves her feeling empty. Scorpia looks unconvinced.

"Catra, you told me you would rather run into a burning building than tell Adora how you feel. Also, you have near-death experiences all the time." Scorpia delivers a rare eye roll. Catra stands by her statement.

OR

After a brush with death, Catra gathers the courage to ask Adora out. Superhero AU.

Notes

Thanks to BlueCoin00 once again for beta reading! I would recommend reading "Masks and Mistakes" before this one if you have not done so. Hope you enjoy it!

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra leaves Alliance headquarters focusing on one thing and one thing only: getting a hot shower. She has images of steam and the smell of lavender, her current body wash, rolling in her head. She tries to ignore the dirt and blood she can feel covering her body.

She checks her watch as she hustles down a familiar street, avoiding cars and pedestrians alike. It’s eight at night. She's been missing for close to twelve hours between her kidnapping, the subsequent battle, and transport back to Bright Moon.

She walks the last stretch between the nearest Bright Moon metro station and her apartment feeling tired to her very bones. She's not sure what state her car is in after her kidnapping and she is too afraid to ask.

The sun set a while ago, leaving a deep chill in its wake. Catra discreetly rubs her arm, creating small flames that warm her but never burn. She walks quickly, her thoughts in a snarl. She doesn't even want to think about how upset Adora will be with her. She just wanted to do something normal with her best friend. Just one time. She should've known better, that was never in the cards for her.

Catra's phone vibrates in her pocket and she sees Adora's contact picture flash on her screen, Adora pulling a ridiculous face one arm wrapped around an impassive Catra. *Speak of the devil.* She her stomach clenchs in panic. She hasn't thought of what to tell Adora about the missed flight. She's bruised, battered, and grimy and in no mood to deal with her disappointed best friend.

She strongly considers letting the call go to voicemail but feels terrible for doing so. She's the bad guy here, not Adora. She answers the phone, an apology on the tip of her lips and no idea where to take the conversation after.

"Catra, I know you're upset that I missed the flight, but I have a reasonable explanation!" Catra’s eyes widen, and she stops in her

tracks. She could only be so lucky. Catra pounces on the opportunity.

"Of course I'm mad, dummy! How could you have missed this, we'd tried to find a week that worked for both of us for ages!" Catra has a hard time keeping the relief out of her voice as she keeps walking towards her apartment. Adora doesn't seem to notice in her frazzled state.

"I know I know! I overslept and then there was an emergency at work. Swift Wind needed another surgery and you know how long he's been our patient." Catra rolls her eyes.

Of course, the horse with chronic intestinal issues rears his ugly head now.

"Dor , I'm sure Razz could have used another vet tech, like Starla." Catra hears Adora's sharp inhale.

"Swifty was my first real patient Cat. Besides, Starla focuses on smaller animals. I'm a horse vet tech in an urban area, when I'm needed, I'm needed you know?" Adora's workaholic tendencies were a common cancelation excuse, although never for something as big as a vacation. Catra recalls another tidbit that doesn't sit well with her.

"Adora, I've known you for five years now , you don't oversleep." Catra honestly isn't sure if Adora sleeps at all. Adora's voice strains.

"I know but I was just so exhausted by work, you know I had to get ahead to take the time off." Catra can tell that some, if not all this, sounds off. Adora's a terrible liar.

If Catra hadn't been kidnapped by an evil scientist, she would be raving mad right now. Catra has a whole superhero alter ego and Adora *still* finds ways to be busier than her. *Ridiculous*. But she wants to rest and doesn't want Adora asking too many questions that

might make her realize Catra also missed their flight. Catra sighs in relief, she can finally see her doorstep.

"Look, we can talk about this tomorrow in person. We wouldn't be able to reschedule the flight for today anyways. We have to have a serious chat about your work boundaries Dora." Catra does worry that Adora gives too much away, never leaving enough for herself.

"Are you going to be able to forgive me?" Adora's voice cracks with fear, the question uncertain. Catra feels whatever anger she's holding seep out of her. Guilt fills her bones instead.

"Adora, of course. You're just going to have to make it up to me." Catra teases, trying to make Adora see that Catra isnt holding a grudge. "We can see if rescheduling would be worth it or if we should just have the ultimate staycation." Adora's breath stutters over the phone.

"I'll make it up to you no problem! Do you want me to go over tonight? I can bring popcorn and ice cream?" Adora proposes, voice filled with relief. Catra's about to say yes when suddenly, something doesnt feel right.

As she fumbles with her keys, Catra sees a creeping shadow out of the corner of her eye. She startles, dropping her phone. She hears Adora's worried voice muffed on the line. Catra looks around her neighborhood and doesnt see anything out of place. She still cant shake the feeling of being watched.

Catra picks up her phone and finally gets her keys in the door jamb.

"Catra! Are you alright?" Adora sounds panicked as she continues to yell into her phone.

"Yeah, Im fine. Sorry, I dropped my phone. Thought I saw something." She still looks around as she finishes fiddling with the key. The lock is old and doesnt usually open on the first try. Adora sighs in relief.

"Okay then. So, Popcorn and ice cream tonight?" Catra hesitates. She finally opens her front door.

"I'd rather see you tomorrow . I'm actually pretty tired. I'm really glad you're safe, Adora." Catra usually needs time to herself after seeing Shadow. Her freakout reminds her of that. The line fills with silence.

"That's okay , I'll see you tomorrow then. Keep safe Cat. Have a goodnight." She hangs up before Catra has a chance to say goodbye. Catra closes the door behind her, drooping heavily against it.

She tries not to think about the shadows she thought she saw near her front door. Her heart is still beating out of her chest, just at the thought that she'd been found. Catra doubts she'll have a good night. She never does when she sees the woman who raised her.

Catra manages to stash all her Wildcat gear in the secret compartment in her closet, pulls off her boots, and enters the bathroom without crying. When she finally reaches the shower, she starts to sob. The cries wrack her body as she gives it permission to freak out after the long day. The hot water feels good on her tired muscles, but her mind keeps racing.

She almost died today. She knows that could happen anytime she puts on her Wildcat mask but it's different-knowing and feeling it.

Usually, when death sweeps close to her, it's in an adrenaline-filled moment, where she feels powerful. Where she defies it head-on. She's never sat quietly waiting for it, slow panic building in her chest like molasses. Somehow, she thinks Hordak knew this type of ending would mess with Catra the most and that's why he did it.

But not somehow, Catra thinks ruefully. The somehow is Shadow. Shadow planted the idea in Hordak's head, knowing how much Catra hated confined spaces. A fear she instilled in Catra when she was a child.

She reaches out to the tiled walls, both to steady herself and feel something cool under her palms. Grounding herself. She hates how the sickly green color looks against the white grout.

She-ra helped Catra stay in the moment, although Catra isn't sure if She-ra even knew Catra was freezing up. She and She-ra aren't close at all, but she can't help but think that now after being stuck in that vault for hours, they might become closer. As she thinks of her conversation with She-ra, her thoughts float to Adora.

Adora, who gives all of herself to everyone and never leaves herself any space to just be. It wasn't love at first sight for Catra but it was a close thing. The first time Adora introduced herself with a beaming smile, Catra thought she might have a heart attack. She can't help but wonder if She-ra is right and Adora could care for her as more than just a friend.

There are moments Catra thinks Adora *must* feel the same way. When they sit together and she feels Adora's stare boring into her, she thinks everything Catra feels can't be one-sided. But then Adora blows Catra off for whatever excuse and Catra feels unsure again.

She feels goosebumps on her arm and realizes the water is running cold her skin pebbling over under the chill. She gets out of the bathroom no less decided on what to do about her feelings for Adora. She closes all her blinds and turns off all the lights. After all, shadows can't survive in only darkness.

She tries to stop thinking about Shadow and instead, she thinks about Adora again. She finds herself crawling into her bed, hope in her heart and doubts in her mind.

There's only one person she could trust with this. She texts Scorpia to see if she wants to get coffee in the morning.

Scorpia picks an unusual coffee spot to meet up, it wasn't close to either of their apartments. It was a local spot, the kind that took their

coffee seriously and had cheerful plants hanging from the ceiling and by the windows.

"You know, I love hanging out with you Wildcat! We always have the best time!" She hasn't seen Scorpia outside of superhero work in a few weeks which was long while for them.

"Scorpia, don't call me Wildcat in public." Catra hisses, looking around to see if anyone was paying attention to the absolute unit of a woman she was getting coffee with. No one seems to be minding them. Catra relaxes back into her chair but continues to scan the room occasionally.

"I've been calling you Wildcat since before we were superheroes." Scorpia points out. Scorpia, and now Entrapta, are the only two people she kept in contact with from before she became a superhero. There's a reason for that.

"Yes, but I'd rather keep that part of my life undisclosed." She isn't sure if Scorpia can tell she means both her childhood and her superhero identity.

"You know, it's very freeing, being myself whether I'm on the job or not." It was a common topic of conversation between Catra and Scorpia. Last year, Scorpia decided to follow the lead of a few Alliance members and retire her superhero name, revealing her identity to the public.

"We fight evil people who have no moral boundaries. Why would I give them more information?" Catra will eat rocks before she outs herself as a superhero publicly.

"I refused to be cowed by villains. Also, I can shoot lighting out of my hands. They don't call me Goddess of Thunder for nothing!" Catra rolls her eyes fondly.

"Scorp, that was one magazine." Scorpia grins cheerily .

"My moms still have it up on the fridge!" Scorpia's mothers are precious, of course they do. Catra switches gears.

"What are we doing so far from everything anyways? What has you trekking all the way out her for caffeine?" Scorpia blushes to the tips of her ears. Catra smirks.

"Or is the cof fee shop close to someone in particular?" Scorpia rubs the back of her neck with her hand.

"So, I think I'm dating Perfuma? I hope I am anyways. She's just the best!" Scorpia's eyes glaze over , cleary thinking about Perfuma. Catra smiles encouragingly.

"The way flower power stares at your back when we're in the middle of a fight makes me think you are probably dating." Catra grins as Scorpia almost spits out her coffee. Catra pauses thoughtfully, tapping one finger to her lips.

"Make sure not to upset her though, Perfuma is scary powerful." Catra once saw her level a five-story building with her vines. She never wants to be on Perfuma's bad side.

"I don't think I will. This feels like what I've been waiting for . She and I just get along so well." Scorpia stares ahead in a daze.

"I'm really happy for you Scorp. Do you know if this is something you have to disclose to Shimmer?" Scorpia frowns at that.

"Hmm, I'm not sure. I think we want to keep it to ourselves for a bit adjust. Not sure that it's the Alliance' s business really." Scorpia's smile turns sly. It's a weird look on her.

"Why? Thinking of getting to know any Alliance members better? You and She-ra seemed awful close yesterday." Catra scof fs and rolls her eyes. There is no universe were Catra ends up with She-ra.

"Oh yeah, being in a death trap that was counting down our oxygen supply was real romantic." Scorpia wilts a little at that. "I'm coordinating the wedding invites right now."

"I'm sorry , I wasn't trying to bring up bad memories. Do you want to talk about what happened?" Scorpia is one of the few people who have an inkling of how hard it is for her when she has to face Shadow. Catra feels panic claw at her throat at the thought of talking about Shadow.

"Actually , I wanted to talk to you about something else." Catra takes a deep breath. "I'm thinking of telling Adora how I feel. Or I don't know, asking her out." She feels her heartbeat racing, it was the first time she admitted those thoughts aloud. Scorpia's eyes grow twice in size.

"Catra that's amazing! You've been pining after Adora since God knows when! Are you going to tell her about you know-" Scorpia leans in conspicuously to whisper, "Wildcat?" Catra immediately scowls. It makes sense that Scorpia doesn't want an alter ego the woman can't be discrete to save her life.

"No Scorp, Wildcat is a private thing for me. The only ones who know are you, Shimmer, and the former Alliance head. The last two only know because it was a condition of entering the Alliance." Catra doesn't add that she probably wouldn't have told Scorpia if she wasn't already involved in the events that led Catra to join the Alliance. Scorpia frowns.

"So what, if you and Adora date you're just going to lie all the time?" Catra shrugs. She can feel panic building, buzzing beneath her skin. She can't let Adora know the type of person she is. Not really . She'll run.

"Scorp, you know how I became Wildcat. I don't want Adora to ever know what I did before. Keeping my personal life separate from all the superhero stuff is the only way I could even try to be normal." Scorpia looks at Catra with mournful eyes. Catra pushes forward.

"Besides, would it be dif ferent from what we are doing now?" Catra hedges. Scorpia narrows her eyes at that.

"Maybe not but a romantic relationship is dif ferent, you know that. I mean, what if you move in together? Or get married? How are you going to explain randomly being gone all the time?" Catra's heart palpitates at the words Adora and marriage in the same sentence. The rest of Scorpia's message feels fuzzy.

"Scorpia I haven't even decided if I am going to ask her out, I need to figure that out first." Scorpia looks contemplative as her vision scans outside of the big bay windows of the cafe.

"Well, if you want my two cents you should come clean about everything. Tell her who you are, and that you've been madly in love with her since the dawn of time. Then ask her out." Scorpia grabs Catra's hand and squeezes.

"She'll say yes because Adora is clearly into you from everything I've heard you say about her." Scorpia chews on the straw of her iced coffee.

"You know, I've been telling you for ages to ask Adora out. What brought this on?" Catra looks into her own cof fee cup, collecting her words.

"I guess just hit me yesterday that we're always in danger. I might not get another five years to gather the courage to tell her." She told She-ra she didn't regret not telling Adora her feelings but now that the dust settled, something about Adora never knowing how important she is to Catra leaves her feeling empty. Scorpia looks unconvinced.

"Catra, you told me you would rather run into a burning building than tell Adora how you feel. Also, you have near-death experiences all the time." Scorpia delivers a rare eye roll. Catra stands by her statement.

I mean I think that's still true. Telling Adora about this feels scarier than anything I've ever done. And I've run into burning buildings before."Catra thinks about it as she leans forward pressing her elbows to the table. "I think I just needed someone to show me that I'm good. That I deserve love too."Catra whispers.

She remembers how awestruck she felt when She-ra said she looks up to Catra, that she made a difference for her and inspired She-ra to join the Alliance. She knew logically that she must inspire some people out there, she's a superhero after all. But She-ra is such an unfailingly good person, so much better than Catra ever could be. To have inspired her to join the Alliance is kind of mindblowing.

Maybe, if Bright Moon's favorite hero could see good in her, Adora would too.

Adora arrives at three in the afternoon, exactly when she said she would. Catra feels like her pointed timeliness is the beginning of her apology tour. Her arms are full of a variety of Catra's favorite snacks. She marches into Catra's apartment and plops down on the couch, grabbing the remote as she goes.

"Okay , so I called the airline and the hotel. I think it might be a good thing that we didn't make it out on the flight yesterday because, apparently, the snow is so heavy near Thaymor that we would've been stuck inside the airport anyways. They canceled all the flights in and out."

Adora keeps rambling about what movie they should watch, barely stopping to take a breath. Her eyes shift around nervously like she isnt sure if she is making things better or worse. Catra barely notices because she has her own nerves to worry about.

Catra sits on the couch trying to work up the courage to say something to Adora. Anything. What should she even say? Should she confess her love flat out? That feels like too much. Maybe she

should ask her out? This is a terrible idea, maybe she is concussed from getting kidnapped yesterday, maybe-

"You are freaking me out Catra." Adora whispers, reaching out to grab Catra's arm. Catra's head snaps to Adora who is eyeing her with concern.

"If this is about the trip, I know we have to talk about it and I'm sorry I didn't call earlier I just-" Catra cuts her off.

"Adora have you ever thought about dating?" Catras asks. The words fly out of her mouth without permission. There, she put it out into the universe. Adora tilts her head like a confused puppy.

"I mean I think everyone thinks of dating sometimes Cat, romantic relationships are ingrained as societal expectations-" Adora rambles on as she interlaces her fingers. Catra makes an impatient noise in the back of her throat, cutting Adora off. She feels her nerves come back full force.

"No, no, that's not what I meant." Catra hesitates and grabs Adora's hand. She doesn't look up from Adora's gorgeous, callused hands when she next speaks.

"Have you ever thought about dating me?" Catra holds her breath, waiting, gently squeezing the hand in hers. At first, Adora looks so shocked and red Catra's afraid she broke her.

Then, the most amazing thing happens. Her smile unfurls and her eyes grow so warm and blue Catra swears she could feel them melting her heart. She should probably get that checked out.

"Only every time I look at you Cat." Adora whispers. Catra looks up at Adora, gobsmacked. *Holy shit that worked.*

"Seriously?" Catra says grabbing Adora's other hand and pulling them both onto her lap. Adora's smile turns uncertain, a worried look starts to crease her brow.

"Of course. It's always been you." Adora's expression is openly vulnerable and Catra realizes she hasn't actually asked her out yet. Catra takes a deep breath and tries to send Adora her most winning smile.

"Adora, do you want to go out on a date with me?" Adora beams a megawatt grin and leans in to kiss her. Catra is so distracted by the kiss she doesn't notice the way Adora's eyes glow as she closes her eyes. The kiss is everything Adora is: strong, steadfast, and exhilarating.

"You won't believe how long I've wanted to do that," Adora murmurs against her lips. Her hands trail Catra's sides and stop at her hips.

"I think I have an idea, dummy." Catra cuddles in close, basking in Adora's warmth. For a moment, one moment of euphoria, Catra considers telling her the rest. *Adora, I'm Wildcat, I've been Wildcat since before we met. Also, I love you.* It's on the tip of her tongue when she hears Shadow's voice echoing in her head. Not one particular phrase, just years of taunts ricocheting back and forth like nails on a chalkboard.

It can wait. She leans in and kisses Adora again and all thoughts of Shadow are gone as if by magic. Adora deepens the kiss, and Catra lets out a yelp as Adora lifts her by her legs, holding her up as they kiss. She hadn't realized Adora was so strong. She can feel Adora's smile on her lips.

Adora pulls away slightly, looking down at Catra. Her eyes are a lovely dark shade of blue, her breath comes and goes in pants.

"So, when are we going on our date?" Catra's heart flutters. She's going on a date with Adora. The next time she sees She-ra, she's going to get her an edible arrangement as a thank you gift.

End Notes

So we have moved on from the "pining best friends who don't know they are superheroes" trope to the "girlfriends who don't know they are superheroes" trope!

I have at least three more one-shots planned for this universe that make up the main "arc." The next one I have mostly written and will be Glimmer's POV.

I will be posting one every Sunday if all goes well. I am open to requests for other things within this universe and outside of it too!

I have a few other works that are currently in progress that I am looking forward to sharing with you all. Hope you all liked this one!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!